his boyish face effused calm. He spoke to nobody. He appeared to be in perpetual meditation.

Dinner, which I rarely had, was served around 8 pm. I survived mostly on bananas and biscuits that some kind prison employees gave me. Antony, a convict awaiting release after a twelve-year jail term, was assigned the duty of locking each one's cell at the end of the day. After he is done with all others, he would get into his cell and lock his own cell before throwing out the key, which would be collected by a prison staff. That was the saddest thing to watch.

I was allowed to keep some books which I tried to read till 10 pm, when the lone bulb in the cell would be switched off. I had also got permission to keep a pen and a diary. I scrawled on this diary the daily happenings, my suspicions about the conspiracy that was keeping me in jail. One day a prison staff took away my diary, saying a senior officer wanted to read it. It never came back. Later I realised that they must have allowed me to keep the diary thinking that I would scribble some 'confessions' that someone was waiting for.

After lights out, I would struggle to sleep. A good three hours before dawn I would be wide awake, staring into the darkness, awaiting the first tinge of light that would creep in through the iron bars. Soon, Antony would be there to unlock the cell.

Antony must have got here when was in his early twenties. Having been a prisoner of good behavior for so many years, he was to be released in a few months. The Indian judicial system made allowances for such prisoners though they were technically sentenced for life.

Going by his demeanour, it was difficult to believe that Antony must have killed someone. Unable to resist my curiosity, one day I asked him if he did.

'Yes, I hacked him sixteen times,' he said.

'Why?'

'I was made to kill. I had no rivalry with the man I killed, but someone made me kill him.'

And then Antony shocked me.